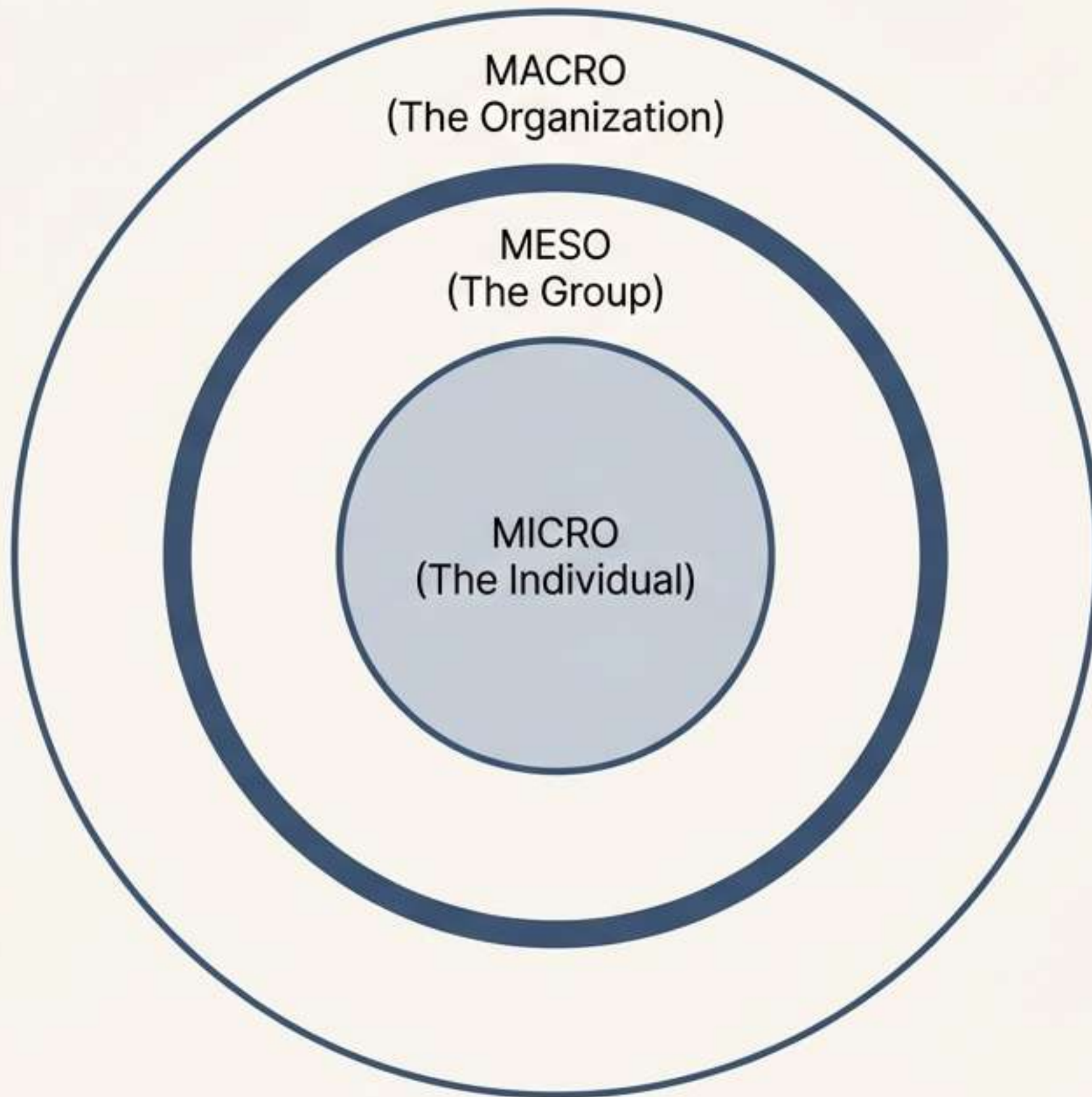


Deconstructing the Organization: The Science of Human Behavior at Work

An evidence-based exploration of Organizational Behavior (OB) through its core levels of analysis.





Organizational Behavior dissects the human element of organizations at three distinct levels.

Formally defined as “the study of human behavior in organizational settings, the interface between human behavior and the organization, and the organization itself.” It notes that individuals behave differently in an organizational role, a key insight from thinker Chester Barnard.

To understand organizational life, we must analyze the interplay between these three levels, starting from the individual and moving outward.

The study of organizations is grounded in diverse and rigorous research methods.



Quantitative Methods

Uses statistical analysis (correlation, regression, meta-analysis) on numerical data to study large groups efficiently and identify broad patterns.



Qualitative Methods

Employs methods like ethnography, case studies, and interviews to build a richer, more in-depth picture of individual behaviors and organizational patterns.



Computer Simulation

Models how organizations operate and individuals behave at a micro-level, allowing researchers to understand emergent phenomena like teamwork dynamics.

The Micro Level: It All Begins with the Individual.



Personality, attitudes, and motivation are the foundational drivers of employee behavior.

Personality & Attitudes

Personality

Consistent patterns of behavior, cognition, and emotion. Research often focuses on the “Big Five” personality traits and their link to job performance.

Job-Related Attitudes

Key attitudes include **Job Satisfaction** (feelings about a job), **Organizational Commitment** (attachment to the organization), and **Job Involvement** (identification with one's job).

Motivation

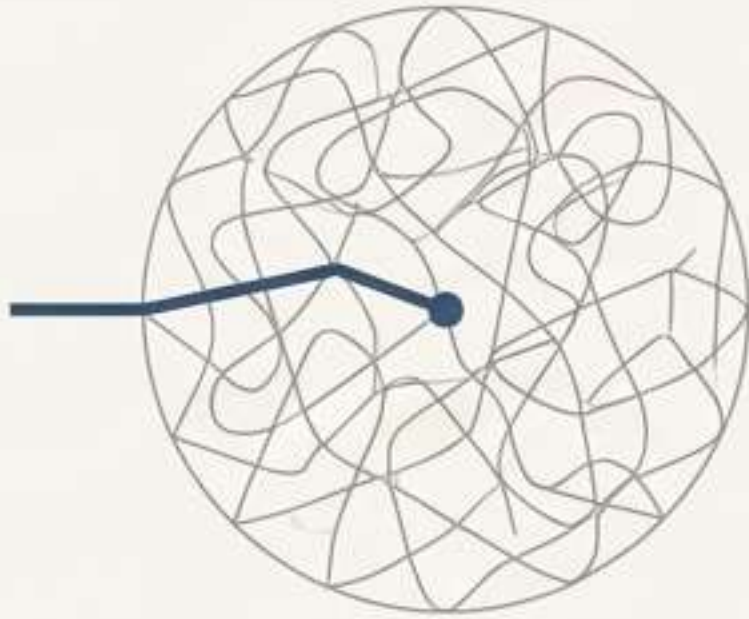
Definition

The set of processes that arouse, direct, and maintain human behavior toward attaining some goal.

Two Types

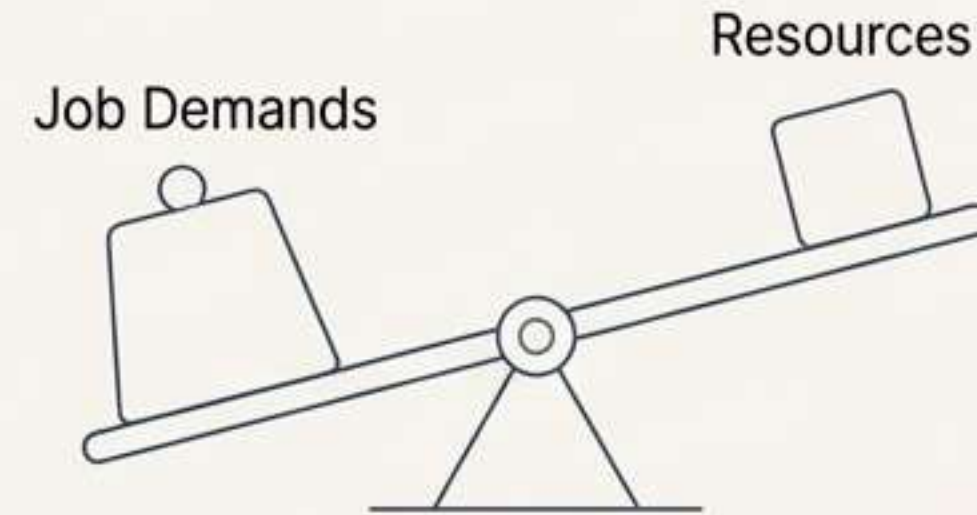
- **Intrinsic Motivation:** Behavior driven by an individual's pure need for self-worth and accomplishment.
- **Extrinsic Motivation:** Behavior triggered by external rewards such as a pay raise, bonuses, or public recognition.

Individual behavior is shaped by cognitive limits and reactions to workplace demands.



Contrary to classical economic theories, Herbert Simon argued that people in organizations operate with **bounded rationality**.

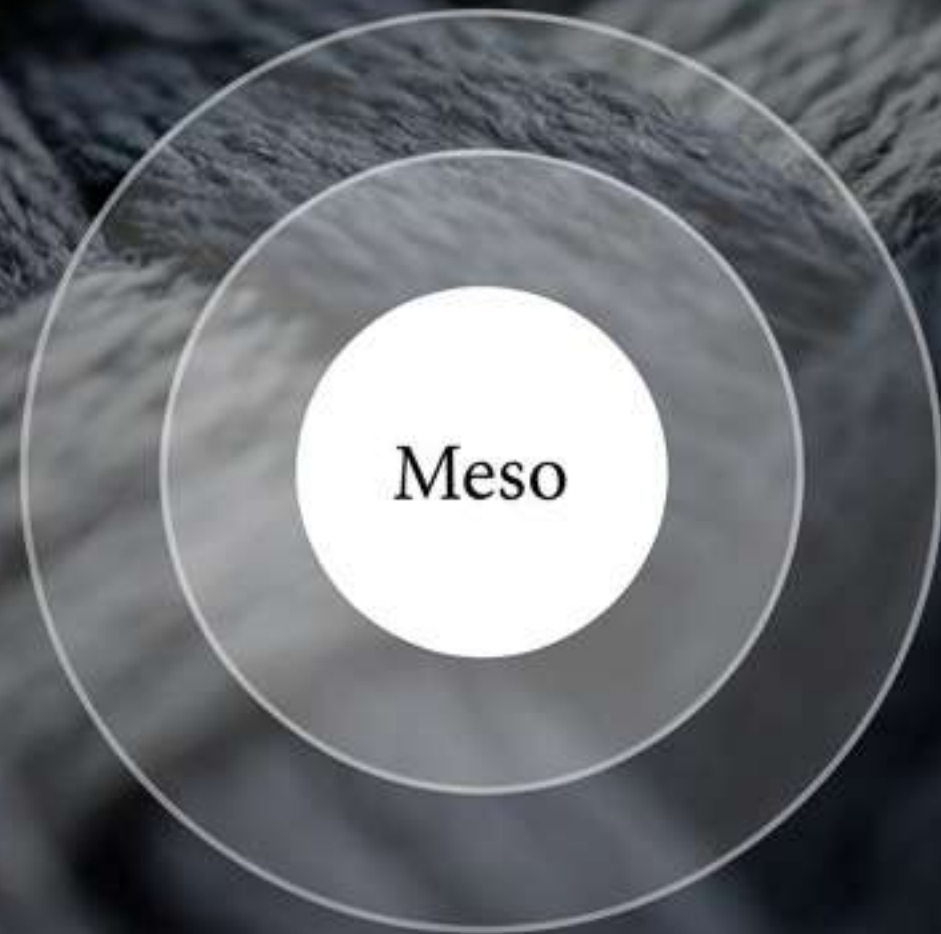
Key Concept: Satisficing: Because cognition is limited, decision-makers often utilize the first marginally acceptable solution they find, rather than searching for the most optimal one.



Definition: Characterized as an imbalance between **job demands** (aspects of the job requiring mental or physical effort) and the **resources** an individual has to manage those demands.

Related Concept: Mention of **Work–family conflict** as a specific stressor where work and family roles are incompatible.

The Meso Level: Where Individuals Become a Team



Leadership is a critical process that shapes group effectiveness and dynamics.

Key Leadership Theories

- **Contingency Theory:** Effective leadership depends on the characteristics of both the leader and the situation.
- **Leader-Member Exchange (LMX) Theory:** Focuses on the quality of the unique exchange relationships between individual supervisors and subordinates.
- **Transformational Leadership:** Concerns behaviors leaders use to inspire high levels of motivation and performance in followers, often leveraging charisma.

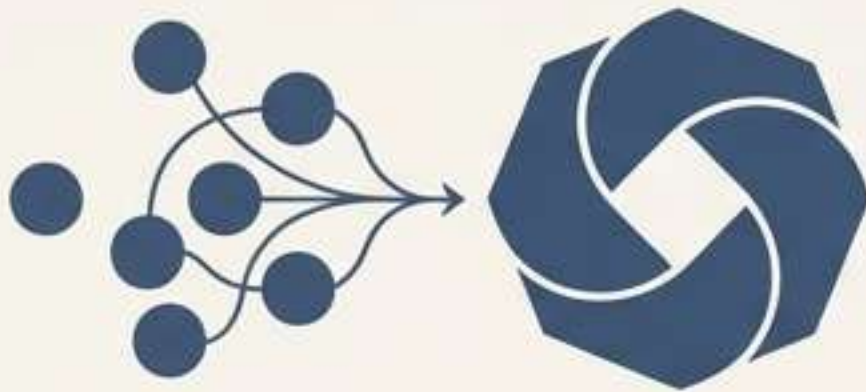
Historical Context

The famous **Hawthorne Studies** of the 1920s revealed that job performance was strongly correlated to social relationships and job content, shifting focus toward motivation and group dynamics.

Group interactions can foster constructive contributions or enable harmful behaviors.

Organizational Citizenship Behavior (OCB)

Employee behavior that goes beyond assigned tasks and actively contributes to the well-being of the organization.



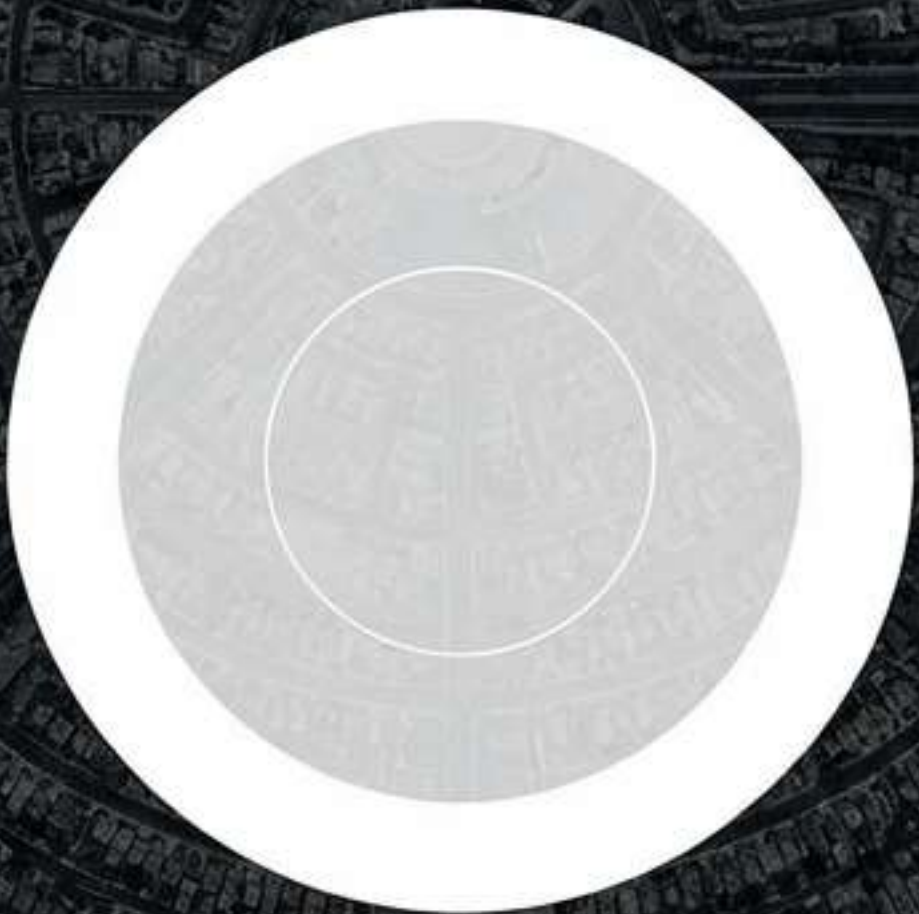
Employee Mistreatment

A pattern of harmful behaviors directed toward individuals.

- Abusive Supervision
- Workplace Bullying
- Workplace Incivility ("low-intensity discourteous and rude behavior")
- Sexual Harassment



The Macro Level: The System That Governs Organizational Life

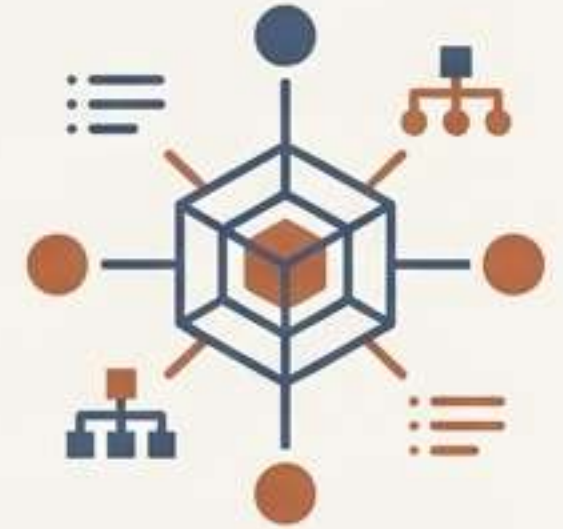


An organization's formal structure and design principles dictate efficiency and control.

Bureaucracy

Max Weber argued that bureaucracy, based on rational-legal principles, was the most technically efficient form of organization.

1. Formal hierarchy
2. Management by rules
3. Functional specialty
4. Selection based on technical qualification
5. Purposeful impersonality

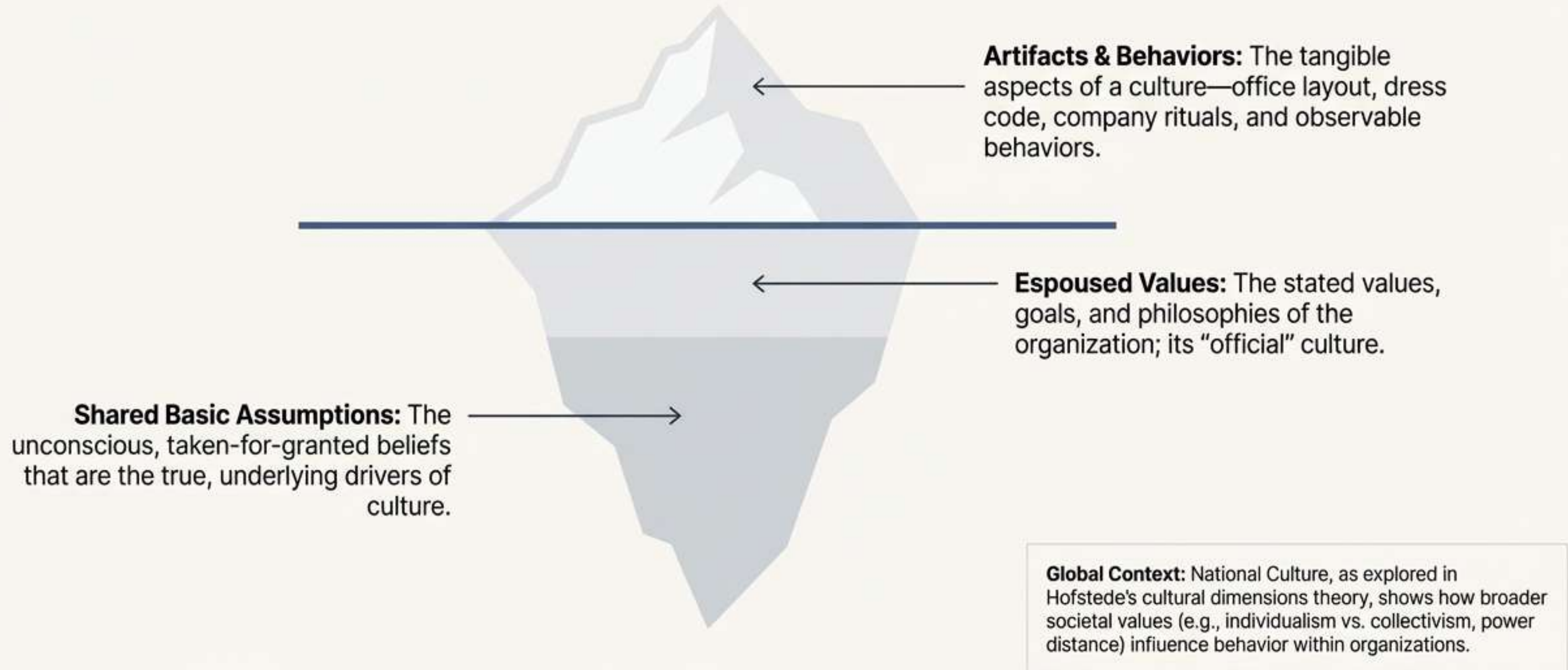


Historical Root: Scientific Management

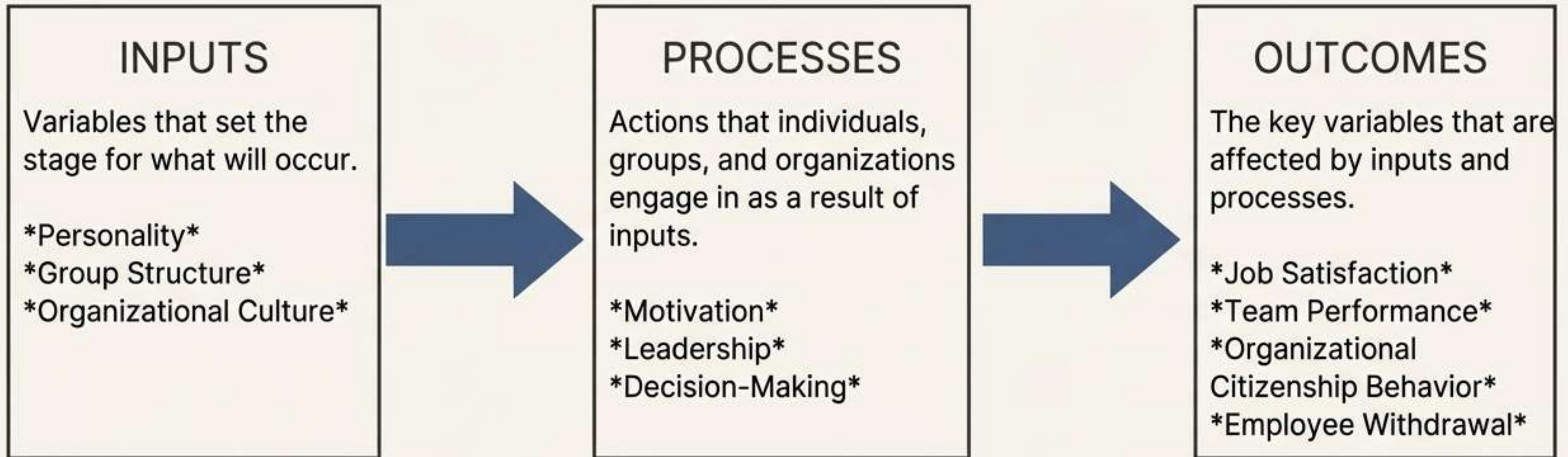
Pioneered by Frederick Taylor, this approach applies engineering principles to management, focusing on incentives and empirically-proven practices to improve productivity and task efficiency.

The field also includes perspectives like Institutional Theory, Systems Theory, and Organizational Ecology.

Organizational culture is the invisible 'software' that shapes values and behaviors



The IPO model reveals how all levels interact to produce organizational outcomes.



This model demonstrates that organizational outcomes are not random; they are the result of a dynamic interplay between factors at the individual, group, and organizational levels.

To improve an organization, we must see it as a complete system of human interaction.



By deconstructing the organization into its micro, meso, and macro components, we can better diagnose problems, design effective interventions, and build healthier, more resilient organizations. The behavior of an organization is ultimately the sum of the behaviors within it.